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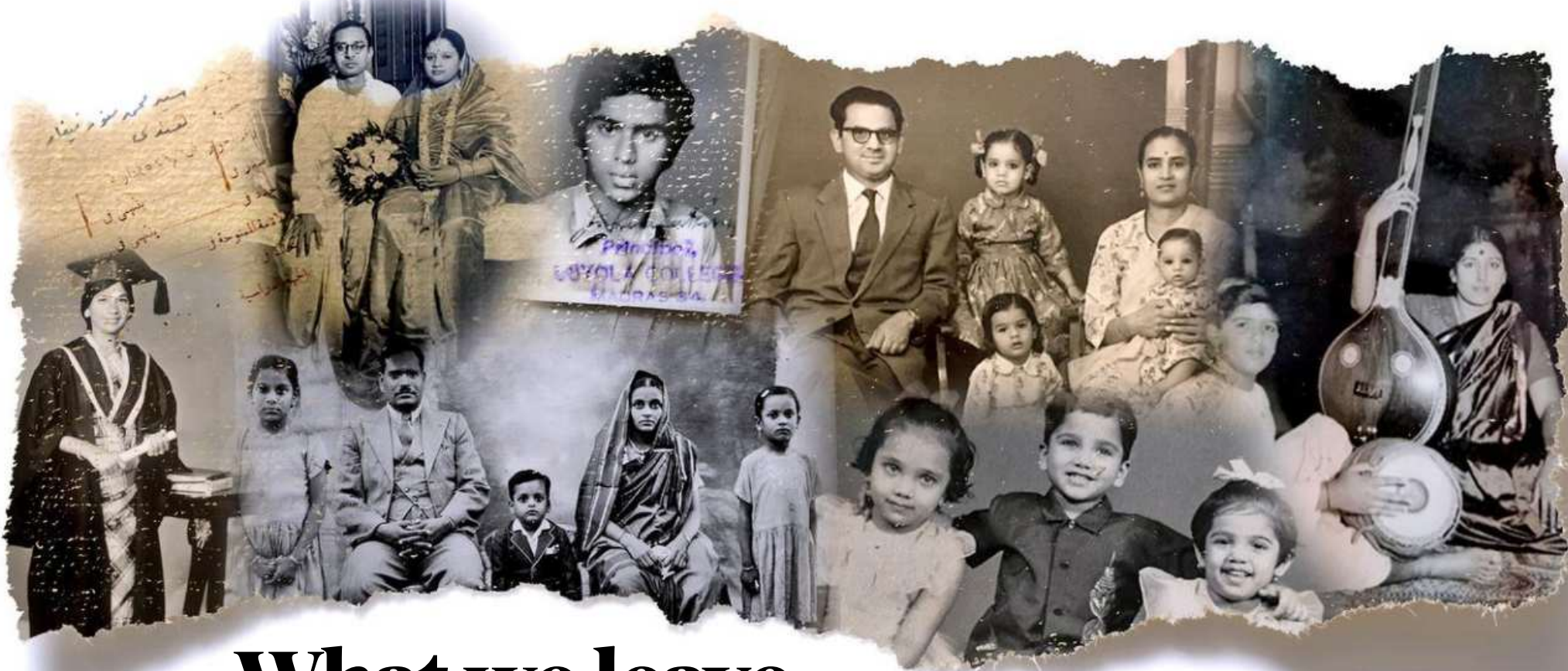
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COLD PLAY
John Francis Daley and Jonathan Goldstein rewind to the 1980s for *Mayday* **P4**



Images from the personal archives of *Team Weekend*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

FULL STORY ON
» PAGE 3

What we leave

behind

From family photographs and heirlooms to oral histories and digital memories, personal archives are helping people preserve family history. We explore why people are creating them, and how you can get started on your own

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pick of the week



Metal night out

Chennai is about to get very, very loud. Brutal Carnage XVII returns to The Spotted Deer bringing together Trojan Horse comeback, death-metal veterans Moral Putrefaction, Bengaluru's chaotic XrepeatX and thrash-death outfit Severed Extremities. Expect pounding riffs, furious drums and a mosh pit in full swing. *On September 12, at The Spotted Deer, Hotel Palomar, from 6pm onwards. Tickets for ₹749 at fanpit.live.*



Festive fit check

Tamil Nadu-based Premam Abaranam and Premam Silks, are bringing their latest edit to The Folly at Amethyst. For your upcoming festive wardrobe, browse handcrafted gold and diamond jewellery neckpieces from Premam Abaranam, alongside Kanjivaram, Benaras, tussar, organza, Paithani and patola saris from Premam Silks. *On September 8 and 9, at The Folly at Amethyst, from 10.30am to 8pm.*



Shop, sip, wander

Vizha is bringing a little Thiruvizha magic to town! Expect nostalgic finds, new discoveries and plenty to munch on — Yettu Coffee, Hew & Frost, Gnack, Anglo Aunty, Butters and Sugars, Kase Cheese, Panagam and Purple Brewery, and many more. For quirky jewellery check out House of Pallikkara and NO.NA.MÉ. Come hungry and curious with your favourite people. *September 5 and 6, 11am to 8pm, at My Bungalow, Teynampet. Entry is free.*



Cut the heartbreak

Love, war and Baroque drama take centrestage as Henry Purcell's *Dido & Aeneas* comes alive in a fully staged production, presented by Madras Musical Association, directed and choreographed by Deepa Nambiar. Expect soaring voices, live orchestral music, choreography and a tragic romance that still knows how to make an entrance. *At Museum Theatre, Egmore, on September 10 and 11, 7pm onwards. Tickets from ₹500 at BookMyShow.com*



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The festive season will soon be upon us, bringing days of merriment with a side of to-do lists: gifts to purchase, new clothes to buy for the family... the tasks are endless. We suggest getting a head start at Craftpreneur 2026, the exhibition by The Crafts Council of India (CCI), which is back after a six-year hiatus.

The upcoming edition will feature 20 brands from across the country working with diverse crafts and artisan groups, crafting everything from kidswear and decor to textiles and pottery.

Lakshmi Vijayaraghavan, member, Crafts Council of India, says Craftpreneur had to pause due to the pandemic, and post-COVID, the focus shifted to other textile shows by the CCI.

"We always wanted to bring back Craftpreneur, but finding a suitable venue was a challenge. We wanted the focus on smaller numbers to ensure the essence of the brands remains. Barring Minimal Indian and Boriya Basta, all the brands are first-timers with CCI," she says. Participating brands include Malaiyyo (jewellery), Mudpie Pottery, Vama (saris), and Earthsongs (apparel), among others.

Take, for instance, Kolkata-based Whitewater Kids, the brainchild of sisters Shweta

Crafting a comeback

Craftpreneur 2026 returns with 20 brands showcasing contemporary clothing, textiles, and décor

and Ankita Dhariwal. Offering unisex apparel for children and women, each collection is inspired by a poem.

"Our silhouettes for children comprise angrakhas, kurtas, pyjamas, jhablas, a range of shirts and shorts. For women, we offer free-size kaftans and shirts," says Shweta, whose latest collection, Dhruv tara, is inspired by the poem *The Story of Dhruv tara*.

The duo works with artisan clusters in Gujarat, West Bengal, and a handloom artisan in Tamil Nadu. "We champion ajrakh and hand-embroidery, and our colours range from indigo to yellow. Alongside apparel, we also craft mustard seed pillows, quilts, dohars, and blankets which we will be bringing for the event," says Shweta.

At Boriya Basta in Uttar



Pradesh, founder Deepika Nigam champions kilim, an ancient weaving technique practised in a small artisan cluster at Khairabad in Sitapur, Uttar Pradesh. "I will



(Clockwise from far left) Products at Boriya Basta; apparel at Kalam Shastra; offerings at The Bindi Project; and a snapshot of Kalam Shastra's apparel. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

shackets, cushion covers, table runners, and other products. We have also recreated the 19th Century chintz textile with an Indian colour palette," he says.

While accessories and jewellery have long been seen as the finishing touches to any look, Meghna Khanna is putting the focus back on the bindi. At The Bindi Project, she focusses on the bindi, which was once a generational heirloom. "I will be bringing our statement bindis, the Tara collection, which comprises 4mm bindis, and the Kamakhya range with bindis in the 18-20 mm range. We also craft bindis with upcycled handloom textiles and leather scrap that are a part of the Poulomi range."

Highlighting South Indian textiles at the event, Rama Srinivasan, founder of Bengaluru-based The Dakshin Studio, is looking forward to bringing her jamakkalam edit to the city.

"This year also marks the fifth year of the brand's jamakkalam journey. The iconic Bhavani jamakkalam, known for its bold stripes, vibrant colours, and strong association with the visual culture of South India, has been transformed into contemporary bags and lifestyle products," says Rama.

The collection, she says, also includes double ikat bags inspired by the Telia Ruma tradition, using handwoven textiles made by weavers from Telangana, and hand-painted Kalamkari silk bags in Kanjeevaram silk. "This collection is really a celebration of South India through its textiles; each has its own history and identity, but together they tell a larger story of the incredible textile traditions of the South," concludes Rama.

From September 10 to 12, at The Folly, Amethyst.



bring semi-circle bags, different variations of sling bags, and home decor pieces like floor rugs, wall hangings, table runners and more. I also plan to bring our signature magazine baskets," says Deepika, adding that all the products are made with 100% cotton yarn "which is first tie-dyed in different shades of the same colour to give the fabric a richer and vibrant look".

South, in focus

From Tirupati, artist Thilak Reddy will showcase kalamkari apparel and textile art from his second-generation artisan workshop, Kalam Shastra. "We fuse traditional motifs with contemporary patterns, and have a permanent collection of artwork panels, shawls, stoles, garments, kaftans, jackets,

Gem alchemy

Studio Renn brings its latest showcase to Collage, featuring old-cut diamonds



Priyamedha Dutta
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Mumbai-based jewellery brand Studio Renn is bringing its contemporary jewellery collection to Chennai with a two-day showcase at Collage on September 11 and 12.

The showcase will be a mix of its older collection and some of the new pieces that will be showcased at the India Art Fair, to be held in Ahmedabad later in the month.

Roshni Jhaveri, who started Studio Renn along with her husband Rahul in 2018, says that most pieces in the collection are unique because of the cuts of the gemstones used. "These are not modern cuts, or cut into standardised shapes. Because of these specific cuts and shapes, the pieces cannot be replicated," says Roshni.

"We are showing old cuts in

diamonds – antique cuts, table cuts, old-mine cuts – this is how diamonds used to be cut by hand before technology made it precise, which gives them their own character and shows the skill of the cutters," she further adds.

They will also be showing gem-quality Columbian emeralds – beads and sugarloafs in a contemporary setting. The collection has rings, earrings and necklaces.

Since its inception, the brand has been known for its unique designs and something that is 'beautifully imperfect', with a design language that moves away from the conventional. For instance, its award-winning Stangler Ring won the Innovation award at Couture in 2021. The ring was an acid-treated concrete construct, reinforced with blackened 18k grey gold and set with brilliant-cut diamonds. It can only be defined as wearable art.

With its sixth year showcasing in Chennai, Roshni says, "this city has a very discerning audience for us, who are not only quality-conscious, but also have a keen eye for design".

The Studio Renn showcase will be at Collage, Rutland Gate, on September 11 and 12. The pieces are priced ₹4 lakh onwards



A star is born

The Evoluzione x Gem Experience showcase on September 10 and 11, will trace Tanzanite's journey from the mines of Tanzania to fine jewellery

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Deep beneath the hills of northern Tanzania, near the foothills of Mount Kilimanjaro, a gemstone was found whose journey began with a stroke of chance. Tanzanite, found in a small area of the Merelani Hills near Arusha, remained unknown until 1967, when Maasai tribesmen are said to have led people to deposits of this blue stone. It was later

brought to public attention by Manuel de Souza. Then, it was Henry B Platt, vice president, Tiffany & Co., who named the stone tanzanite after Tanzania. That little-known mineral caught the attention of jewellers and gemologists, ultimately making its mark in the international luxury market.

From East Africa, Tanzanite is making its way to Chennai on September 10, as Evoluzione, in



Jewellery collection from Gem Experience; and miners from Merelani Hills mine. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



collaboration with Gem Experience, presents The Origins of Tanzanite: The Stone With a Story. The two-day showcase will celebrate the gemstone's journey, rarity and allure.

Hosted by entrepreneur Mita Banker, the event will open on September 10, from 11am to 12.30pm with a conversation featuring Gem Experience's second-generation founder and CEO, Akshit Gokhroo, and Vidya Gajapathi Raju Singh, entrepreneur and member of the erstwhile royal family of Vizianagaram. The conversation will delve into Tanzanite's origins, its extraction and geological story, as well as the gemstone's finite availability.

While Tanzanite is central to the narrative, the gemstone curation also includes Pink Spinel, Rose Rhodolite, Tsavorite, Malaya Garnet, Aquamarine and Mint Garnet, among others. One of the special pieces is called Ember. It is a necklace created over 160 man-hours, the necklace featuring a display of 156 bead-cut pink spinels from Mahenge, East Africa. It is interwoven with 11-carat portrait cut and 23.18-carat round brilliant cut diamonds to allow light flow.

Cuts and carats

The collection is divided into two categories – the fine and prêt collections, which feature lighter, easy-to-wear pieces designed for everyday occasions and curated for a younger generation. It includes the brand's signature Padma Cut, along with the Swirl, Safar and Royal Starling collections, which will have neckpieces, rings and earrings.

The high jewellery collection, meanwhile, goes beyond Ember to include statement neckpieces such as Jardin Bleu, crafted with Tanzanite, and Shamsa, featuring a pink spinel cabochon.

The journey of Gem Experience started 30 years back with Rakesh Gokhroo, who initially

started by sourcing gemstones from East Africa, sending them to manufacturers around the world. "Over time, he got into mining gemstones, which are extremely rare and found only in Tanzania, particularly Tanzanite," says Akshit.

Five years ago, the company decided to take its gemstone journey a step further by launching its own brand to give customers a deeper understanding of the rare gemstones found in East Africa. "Our concept is essentially mine-to-masterpiece – we mine the gemstones ourselves, manufacture them, and then design the jewellery in-house. Everything is vertically integrated," he says.

Mines to red carpet

Tanzanite's journey from a gemstone to a red-carpet moment is also being shaped by pop culture. Most recently at the 2026 Met Gala, Indian philanthropist Sudha Reddy was seen donning a 550-carat Tanzanite necklace, while Céline Dion recently wore a 49-carat Tanzanite Bulgari choker for the cover of *Harper's Bazaar*. Beyoncé too has been seen wearing a Tanzanite ring. India's moment of Tanzanite came when Vicky Kaushal gifted a Tanzanite ring from Tiffany & Co to Katrina Kaif for their engagement.

Vidya, who summited Mount Kilimanjaro last year in March at the age of 72, says, "As someone who has been to Tanzania and was astonished by its beauty, it is also a great opportunity for people to understand a piece of history and culture of this place through its jewellery."

The Evoluzione x Gem Experience showcase is at Evoluzione, Khader Nawaz Khan Road, September 10-11. To attend the talk on September 10, RSVP 9940471634.



(Far left) A personal archive being crafted; and images from the personal archives of *Team Weekend*. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



change, or simply the passing of generations. That is why I feel now is the right time to begin preserving these stories and objects before they disappear.”

Beyond materiality

For Paarvathi Om, an interdisciplinary artist and researcher based in Edayanchavadi, near Auroville, the definition of a personal archive also includes her own physical body. “When the body is approached as the archive, one begins to sense the expanse of the memories and experiences stored, submerged and knotted. I was interested in retrieval: who all am I, without my knowing,” says Paarvathi, who has been deeply involved in the CPA programme.

Working through the body, a repository of somatic memory, means not generating more archival material but discovering what already exists, an insight she believes comes from her theatre practice. “Embodied archiving and its retrieval inform much of my theatre process, where they are free to interact with each other, and a fresh new archive has a chance to emerge,” explains Paarvathi, who

finds this process subversive. “That is the larger frame that holds it, and allows me to make meaning.”

In her book, *The Archive and the Repertoire*, published by Duke University Press, performance studies scholar Diana Taylor writes that ‘embodied performances have always played a central role in conserving memory and consolidating identities in literate, semi-literate, and digital societies’.

There is often a tension between ‘the archive of supposedly enduring materials (ie, texts, documents, buildings, bones) and the so-called ephemeral repertoire of embodied practice/knowledge (ie, spoken language, dance, sports, ritual),’ she writes, further arguing that the repertoire, like the archive, is mediated. “The process of selection, memorisation or internalisation, and transmission takes place within (and in turn helps constitute) specific systems of representation,” states Taylor.

Lakshmana KP, who has been exploring questions about Dalit aesthetics in performance, too, agrees that while embodied archiving is not a conventional way of archiving, it functions as a source of inspiration.

“I go back to the memories and lived experiences of not just myself, but the actors I work with. Not just traumatic experiences, but the instruments that they have seen, the songs they have heard, their mythologies,” says the founding member of the Bengaluru-based Jangama Collective, a group of actors who use theatre to create cultural, political and social awareness. “I draw from those to build a world and construct a physicality,” he says.

For him, the knowledge of marginalised communities exists in

their ritual, in their instruments, their bodies, their voices, their food cultures, says Lakshmana.

“To tap into the knowledge systems of these communities, you have to get into these things, so the form of archiving is very different,” he adds.

Reclaiming narrative

Regardless of its form, building a personal archive often helps reclaim narrative, especially for people that mainstream history leaves out. “Difficult and oppressed histories are better narrated by the people who have gone through them,” says Ishita, who thinks of personal archiving as a form of dissent. “The State or institution will choose to ignore or erase you, but you still have the power to tell your story,” she says.

Debankita agrees. “When you read about the history of Bengal, it is essentially focussed on the deltaic Ganga Valley region. There is this assumption that this represents Bengal’s entire space-time history, but that is not the case.”

According to her, the people living along the north-eastern range of the Himalayas that fall within the modern-day boundaries of Bengal and the Brahmaputra Valley of Assam also possess vibrant cultures, languages, cuisine, histories and stories, but this is often exoticised or simply overlooked. “We never talk about these regions that equally felt significant consequences following the 1947 Partition. Personal archiving, for me, therefore helps decolonise and de-institutionalise these histories and archives, and reclaim representation.

She believes that it is equally critical to create a network of personal archives of people whose stories are little-known.

“The most important thing for me to understand is that the place where I come from was shaped into a shared living space both by the local Himalayan and foothill communities, the latter of whom were displaced and had to migrate in search of a new home and belonging following the events leading to pre-Partition and the Partition,” she states. Then adds, “So, if I can join other people’s stories as well, it will be more fruitful.”

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Debankita Das’ interest in personal archiving stems from her family’s experience of the Partition. “My grandfather and his family migrated from Dhaka to the eastern Himalayan region of Bengal in 1946, while my grandmother comes from Assam’s Tezpur region. So I wanted to look at these interlinked histories,” says the doctoral researcher at the School of Social Sciences, University of Hyderabad.

This quest drove her to create a personal memorial archive of her grandmother’s life. “She passed away suddenly in 2020, which was a huge shock for me. So, to talk about her ancestral history, and then expand it to my grandfather’s history was cathartic for me,” says Debankita, who included family photographs, handwritten letters, and objects that belonged to her grandmother, such as her crochet work, ritualistic paraphernalia and a medicine box to the archive.

A rising trend
Personal archives, unlike institutional archives, are, by definition, deeply personalised in their form, but they too have historical significance.

“The personal is not about me, my family or my community, but rather a more self-experienced and relatable way of looking at history,” clarifies Ishita Shah, the lead curator of the Constructing Personal Archives (CPA) programme. They differ from institutional archives in yet another way: rather than focus on

scale, milestones, and impact, personal archives offer insights into people’s lived experiences, “their everydayness, value system and behind-the-scenes stories”.

In recent years, there has been a growing interest in creating personal archives, a trend Ishita says can be linked, at least in part, to COVID-19 and its aftermath. “The pandemic and the other uncertainties and fragilities of the world around us have brought this interest. Even if people are not interested in the larger idea of history, they are interested in their sense of lineage and belonging, trying to find things that they feel very connected to,” says Ishita.

In the overabundance we live in, to practise restraint and choice is an informed and conscious thought, feels Ishita, who believes archiving helps balance the

Tips to store objects in a personal archive

Sindhu Nagaraja, the chief conservator at Khandya Station, a specialised centre for art, archaeology, and conservation based in Bengaluru, offers practical tips for maintaining a personal archive. “We suggest buffering, which involves using either acid-free paper boxes or even normal good-quality, destarched cotton cloth.”

Objects should be wrapped in multiple layers, she says, if they need to be protected from the elements. “This way, the object is not exposed too much. Even if there is mould growth due to humidity, it will remain on the surface layers. It won’t penetrate inside,” explains Sindhu, adding that silica gel, which absorbs excess moisture, can be very useful.

Among the most common objects that go into a personal archive are old photographs. In her view, keeping vintage photographs in albums is one of the worst things one can do. Instead, it is best to keep them separately, just interleaving them with archival-grade, unbuffered sheets of paper, “which are quite affordable in the Indian market”.

These should then be placed in an archival sleeve or self-made archival pockets and put inside an archival box. The pockets can later go inside a small archival folder, says Sindhu, who is also a conservator at Archives at NCBS and conservation consultant at the archive of IIT Madras. And yes, labelling and providing context are also important parts of archiving, says IFA’s Biswadeep. “You need to sit down and try to think about why something, whether in the physical or digital realm, is important, and label and name it in a way that makes it easy to go back and retrieve,” he says.

relationship between why something is important and how it will be relevant in the future.

“The mechanisms of labelling, cataloguing, and finding aids become very important, allowing you to keep things for the long-term, find them easily and still be very efficient about how you collect and organise them, especially in a country like ours where space is highly constrained and political.”

In the view of Biswadeep Chakraborty, archivist at India Foundation For The Arts (IFA), Bengaluru, the growing interest in personal and family archives is the result of the realisation “that history is not only made by governments and institutional narratives, but also by ordinary day-to-day people and their lived experience,” he says.

The social media angle

Thanks to our smartphones, it is easy to learn about history, and to understand that history is not just in the written annals of kings, queens and governments, he further adds. “We are also learning so much about social, cultural and personal history now because of social media.”

And yes, a longing to hold on to memories of a slower time is also a driver of personal archiving. “Day-by-day, people are realising the importance of preservation,” says Biswadeep, who recently conducted a hands-on free workshop, titled Archiving the Personal at IFA, “keeping in mind that there are so many people who want to preserve their memories and artefacts, but they don’t know how to do it.”

He lists the objects that participants arrived with – a pendant, purse, football memorabilia, a film reel and an HMT watch – and says, “Material objects are central to archives, in general, and historical research because they preserve evidence of human life that written records alone cannot capture.”

Fareeda AM, a video editor who attended the workshop and hopes to start her own personal archive, echoes Biswadeep’s perspective. “The workshop helped me see archiving as a way of documenting ordinary things that carry personal, cultural, and historical value,” she says, adding that we often take these ordinary objects for granted until they are gone.

Archiving, for her, is about preserving memories and ways of living. “It helps us understand what is being lost over time, whether through climate change, social



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All are welcome.

🌳🌳🌳

Puja Talwar

Scottish filmmaker Kevin Macdonald has made a career out of studying the human breaking point. From the agonising physical entrapment of *Touching the Void* (2003) to the real-time hostage terror of the Academy Award-winning *One Day in September* (1999), Macdonald's lens consistently permeates the human psyche as characters process claustrophobic, life-or-death pressure.

In his latest psychological thriller, *The Runner*, he taps into technology's chokehold on humans. At a time when we have handed control of our lives to the phones in our palms, the film highlights the terrifying extent of this dependency and the ways it can be turned against us.

“This is a modern paranoia. We’re all terrified of the influence of the technology around us,” Macdonald tells *The Hindu* in an exclusive conversation over Zoom. “We all know that we’re being controlled, manipulated, and observed... your phone is actually controlling you like a puppet,” he adds.

The Runner revolves around Maia (Gal Gadot), a high-powered attorney and single mother whose life is upended after a mysterious phone call. To save her abducted son's life, she must follow cryptic commands and race against time, sprinting across London's bustling labyrinth of streets and its underground tracks.

For Macdonald, subverting audience expectations was central to the film's structural tension. Making his return to Hollywood commercial filmmaking, and to major studio-backed narrative with Amazon MGM, after a run of prestige documentary profiles such as *Whitney* (2018), *High & Low* - John Gagliano (2023), *One to One: John & Yoko* (2024) and the recent *A Beautiful Obsession* (2026), a raw and intimate

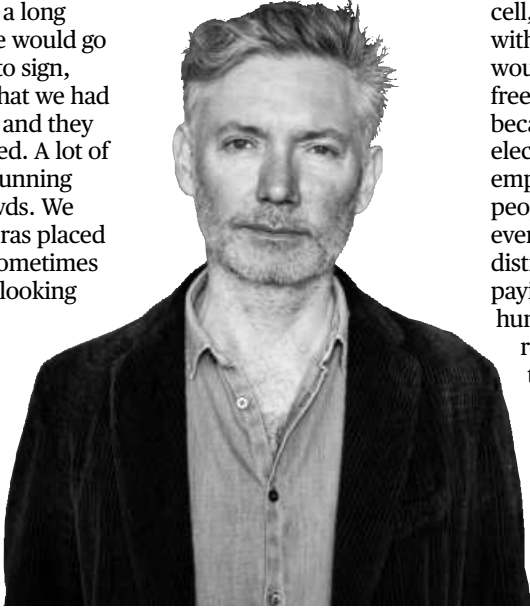


portrait of Manchester City manager Pep Guardiola, he notes that there was a distinct, unsettling thrill in watching an actor globally recognised as an invincible superhero stripped of her armour.

The project adopts a cinéma-vérité style in its visual narrative, using shaky, handheld camera work to create a sense of events unfolding in real time.

"I loved the simplicity of the story, and it was so different from what I'd done," says the director.

"A lot of the characters we just filmed on a long lens. And then we would go up and get them to sign, informing them that we had them on camera, and they were pretty thrilled. A lot of the time, Maia's running through real crowds. We had hidden cameras placed everywhere. So sometimes you'll see people looking around at her because it's Gal Gadot running through crowded London streets, and that worked for the story because it's like, 'who's this woman running so



A still from the film; and (below) director Kevin Macdonald.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

protagonist against a disembodied antagonist, an unknown caller (Damian Lewis), is an ironic take on how, despite our connections and independence, humans are more enslaved than ever before.

"Almost every film that I've done.... is about people caught in impossible situations," says Macdonald. "In this case, instead of being confined to a prison cell, she (Maia) is a prisoner within a city of millions. You would think she could find freedom, but she can't because she's caught in this electronic net. That's why I emphasise her seeing people on their phones everywhere – everyone is distracted, and nobody is paying attention to her human crisis. It is rewarding to make a film that serves as real entertainment but also carries a subtle message in a satirical way."

The Runner is currently streaming on Prime Video

Mayday mayhem

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It was a little surreal to watch John Francis Daley, who played little Sam Weir from *Freaky & Geeks*, all grown up and firmly ensconced in the movie business. To imagine that same dorky Sam, once hunched over D&D with his nerdy friends, now making films with Jonathan Goldstein, from *Game Night* to *Dungeons & Dragons: Honor Among Thieves*, made me well up with nostalgia.

The filmmakers' latest film, *Mayday*, takes their genre-fluent sensibilities into the Cold War. Written and directed by the duo for Apple Original Films, the action-comedy stars Ryan Reynolds as Troy Kelly, a hotshot US Navy pilot stranded behind enemy lines after a covert mission goes awry, and Kenneth Branagh as Nikolai 'Nick' Ustinov, an eccentric former KGB agent who becomes his unlikely ally.

Largely set in Soviet Russia and steeped in 1980s pop-cultural iconography, *Mayday* finds the two filmmakers leaning into the decade's particular blend of Cold War paranoia and pop-cultural excess.

Spycraft and the 1980s

Mayday pays close attention to period-specific technology to KGB tradecraft.

"I was a big fan of the James Bond movies as a kid, still am. I love the notion of a seemingly ordinary person who is not quite a superhero, but almost one. And that's what Kenneth Branagh is in this movie," Goldstein says.

“We did do a lot of research in terms of what technology might have been available to them during the time,” Goldstein says. “The Altai satellite phone that they go find, was a real thing. So we try to be as true to life and reality....”

That attention to period detail extends to the film's contrasting visions of America and the Soviet Union.

"I did draw a lot of inspiration from the aesthetic and the clothes and the pop culture of the '80s while making this film." This reflects in the costumes designed by Debra McGuire, who worked with Daley on *Freaks & Geeks*,

and later reunited with him for *Game Night* and now *Mayday*.

Turning *Top Gun* on its head
 “*Top Gun* is a seminal film for Americans in particular, because I think they look at Maverick as both the iconic American hero, and a rebel at the same time,” Goldstein says.

That idea became the blueprint for Reynolds' Troy. He notes, "That's what partly drew us to this notion when we started coming up with the idea of *Mayday*: how do you take that iconic figure and turn it on its head a little bit by putting him in a situation where he can't solve every problem, where he actually needs the enemy, 'to save his butt'."

The film also borrows from the practical aerial work of Joseph Kosinski's *Top Gun*:



Maverick. "We did a month of aerial photography in the South of France before we shot principal photography. We took these French fighter jets and re-skinned them in post-production to look like F-18s," Daley says.

Daley adds, "We never intended the film to be too much of a homage to or satire of *Top Gun*. Rather, we wanted to look at the nostalgia and fandom people have for the film."

The production was committed to realism. For one sequence, the filmmakers tracked down an actual Soviet Intercontinental Ballistic Missile launch trailer in Hungary and built a replica nuclear missile to go on top of it.

“Luckily, we found a man in Hungary who had collected Soviet weapons from the Cold War period, including that ICBM launch trailer, the bottom part of it, which we then built a

sort of fake ICBM missile to go on top of,” Goldstein says.

Marcin Dorociński plays Alexander Volkov, a KGB officer pursuing Troy and Nick, who wants to see the Gorbachev era's *glasnost* reforms brought to an end. The Polish stalwart, best known internationally for playing Vasily Borgov, the formidable Russian chess grandmaster opposite Anya Taylor-Joy in *The Queen's Gambit*, brings a similar inscrutable quality to *Mayday*.

The soundtrack

Van Halen's 'Jump' opens the film, while Bruce Springsteen's 'I'm on Fire' soundtracks a montage of Troy and Nikolai driving through Russia.

“Elvis Costello, Joe Jackson, Lou Reed and Frank Zappa... That was my kind of music growing up that I loved,” Goldstein says.

Daley says, "I like Devo and Duran Duran and a number of others. The 1990s music scene was more my generation, just because I was born in 1985."

Mayday is streaming
on Apple TV



Hindi

A social autopsy of patriarchy



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At a time when the diary of police procedurals is cluttered with gravity-defying cops and preachy social commentaries masquerading as investigative dramas, *Babita Singh* reports with a quiet yet telling subversion.

The biting social critique tells us how our society tolerates a woman’s professional ambition only on the condition of absolute domestic continuity. Her career must remain invisible to the men of the house; it cannot cost them their hot meals or their sense of absolute supremacy. Of course, there is a murder investigation as well, but it works as a narrative camouflage. The mystery lies in decoding the pervasive patriarchy.

A pliant, underconfident Assistant Sub-Inspector in Bhopal who joined the force on a compassionate appointment following her brave father’s death, Babita Singh (Nimisha Sajayan) is constantly underestimated and relegated to mundane paperwork. Eager for field duty, she accepts a fake disciplinary charge just to secure leave and appease her husband, Sharad (Anshuman Pushkar), and his family.

As she travels with Sharad to his home in Rewa to organise and attend her sister-in-law’s baby shower, Babita is almost subsumed by everyday patriarchy that envelops her unannounced. Outside the railway station, Babita briefly reunites with her childhood friend, Banshi (Barun Sobti), a local artist known for his honesty and simplicity. However, on the very night of their reunion, Banshi is mysteriously murdered. Recognising the systemic apathy of the local police and the community’s desire to sweep his death under the rug, Babita’s inherent sense of integrity is triggered.

The film’s biggest strength is its grounded realism, whether it is Babita’s stifling domestic routine, official impediments, innuendos about her body weight and hormonal issues, or her awakening. Director Ambiecka Pandit and writer Amita Vyas capture the everyday discrimination most women navigate in real life.

A silent but interesting parallel runs between the corruption within the police station and the oppression within the household. Babita’s male superior (Rajesh Kumar) and her husband seem to share the same playbook. Both demand her compliance, both gaslight her into believing she is incompetent, and both use her people-pleasing nature to keep her silent. We discover her fight is not against two systems; it is against a singular patriarchal network.

As is frequently the case with contemporary noir, Ambiecka is far more interested in the *why* of the community’s collective silence rather than the *how* of the physical crime. Consequently, the narrative’s plot holes are never fully covered by its thematic intent. While the film succeeds as a visceral social dissection, it eventually fumbles as an investigative thriller in its final leg.

Babita Singh Reporting is currently streaming on Amazon Prime.

Babita Singh Reporting

Director: Ambiecka Pandit

Cast: Nimisha Sajayan, Anshuman Pushkar, Barun Sobti, Sunita Rajwar, Rajesh Kumar

Synopsis: Suspended from service, an unauthorised investigation helps ASI Babita Singh break free from her people-pleasing conditioning and a suffocating marital home.



An old-school entertainer

With its warm and colourful frames, soulful songs, and low-stakes drama, Vishnu Edavan’s film brings back a comforting strain of Tamil cinema, with a superb cast

Tamil

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In the latest Tamil film *Hi*, Kavin is Mayilsamy, a sensitive man in Coimbatore who cannot hide his vulnerabilities as easily. Seeing him unable to cope with a rejection, his family forcibly arranges a marital alliance for him. Mayil elopes to Chennai. Nayanthara plays Devayani, a young Pollachi woman as sharp as a knife, whose irresponsible, drunkard father doesn’t see the issue in getting her married to an abusive man. On the day of her wedding, she elopes to Chennai.

When the two meet on a rainy evening, Mayil dons a translucent raincoat – which must also shield his heart, broken earlier under a fake rain shower. Devayani waves ‘hi’ to Mayil with a sickle in her hand, the one she brought from home to defend herself in an unknown city – she protects her heart with thorns and sharp edges, having been repeatedly distressed by men.

He breaks easily. She holds herself together with all her might. He is a Bhagyaraj-esque hero and a Rajinikanth fan, rejected for not being a Kamal Haasan in romance. She is an 80s Radikaa Sarathkumar-coded, spirited woman and a Kamal Haasan fan wanting an honest life on her terms. These are the simple and sweet characters who anchor lyricist-filmmaker Vishnu Edavan’s *Hi*, a humble family entertainer about love, confronting fears, and living with hope.

During pre-release promotions, director Vishnu repeatedly stated he wished to make an old-school “K-TV comfort-watch” that filmmakers like KS Ravikumar, Vikraman, Visu, and V Sekhar built careers on. While many similar promises have gone awry in the past, *Hi* is

Hi

Director: Vishnu Edavan

Cast: Kavin, Nayanthara, Radikaa Sarathkumar, Bhagyaraj, Prabhu

Storyline: A vulnerable young man and a fiercely independent woman pretend to be a couple, forcing them to confront their fears, families and feelings



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precisely that quintessential comfort film that Tamil cinema has been missing for quite some time. Films in this particular sub-genre feature big joint families, colourful occasions, soulful songs, some good drama, and one simple twist that holds the one-liner.

Here, the story kicks off when Mayil, in an instinctive move to save the day, lies about his relationship with Devayani to their parents. Veteran actor Prabhu reminds us of why he is called Ilaya Thilagam in his role as Devayani’s father, who turned to alcohol when his wife walked away decades ago. Veteran Radikaa, who is delivering a scene-stealing performance for the third consecutive Friday this month, plays Mayil’s mother. But the more interesting casting choice is late veteran Bhagyaraj as the father to a man who might remind many Tamil cinema fans of the 80s Bhagyaraj. These stalwarts, along with great performances by the lead pair and superb supporting actors like Adithya Kathir, Khureshi, and Sathyan, make *Hi* one of the most well-cast, well-performed films of 2026.

I speak of performances first because writer-director Vishnu seems to have relied on this casting to do the heavy lifting – and in films that are almost too breezy for present-day palettes, the high-pitched moments need to work as well as in *Hi*. Take, for instance, the scene in which Bhagyaraj’s character must open up to his depressed son, or a superb scene in which Prabhu realises what he had been missing due to his alcoholism. Watch how Nayanthara emotes the many mixed emotions she feels upon seeing her father turn over a new leaf. Kavin is easily one of the few young talents who could make you laugh and tug at your heartstrings in a short span, and he aces almost all his scenes.

I could go on and on, but it’s a pleasure to see such performers not used as mere tokens, but given characters with heft and real purpose in the story. The conviction

the makers had in this school of cinema is evident in how the film never tries to punch above its weight. The stakes are kept low, and no unnecessary twists throw you off. Of course, some scenes in the second half drag on. Some, like one that transpires in a hotel’s powder room, felt too convenient and poorly staged. Still, even through these dull stretches, something keeps you invested, like some good old humour and Jen Martin’s tastefully conceived songs.

Even if you nitpick, *Hi* will convince you to forgive it, for there’s real effort to make a clean, honest film. Vishnu is a writer who crosses his t’s. How does Devayani, a girl who grew up in such a low-income background, end up wearing such high-fashion clothes? Because the friend (Amrutha Srinivasan) who helps Devayani in Chennai is a costume designer. Why does Devayani take some time to realise the weight of the lie Mayil inadvertently thrust on her? Because she has internalised her hatred for her mother so much that she understands the emotional stakes only in the presence of another mother (Mayil’s mother).

You might hear people say how much they miss simple family entertainers you could watch just for the pleasure of it. If you have followed the industry closely, many stakeholders call good family entertainers a sign of the industry’s good health. This film proves all those sentiments. At one point, when Devayani tells Mayil, “*Azhuvuradhu la enna aambala pombala?* (What does crying have to do with being a man or a woman?)”, both the masculine and feminine parts of me felt validated and heard. Only good, honest films can do that. Most importantly, the late legendary Bhagyaraj sir would be proud to have *Hi* – a film that pays tribute to his style of cinema – as one of his last on-screen appearances. We miss you dearly, sir.

Hi is currently running in theatres

Yash and Geetu Mohandas’ clash of visions is an ambitious misfire

Kannada

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50-50. That’s the balance one hopes for when a director and actor with polar-opposite sensibilities come together. You expect their individual styles to meet somewhere in the middle, creating a blend that belongs to both. In *Toxic: A Fairy Tale for Grown Ups*, the disconnect between two people who see cinema differently is apparent. The result is an ambitious misfire.

Yash, who co-wrote the movie, said *Toxic* was going to be “a gangster drama with a difference.” The actor was right. The problem is that those ideas are brought to the screen with terrible execution.

The gangster-drama thread revolves around the opium trade in Goa around Independence, when the region was still under Portuguese rule. Raya (Yash), a trusted associate of crime boss Salvador, sets his sights on monopolising the trade. The



film’s human side explores Raya’s complicated relationship with women. He is drawn to Rebecca (Tara Sutaria), Salvador’s daughter, but what he feels for her is driven more by need than genuine affection. Things take a turn when he falls in love with Nadia (Kiara Advani), a circus performer.

Mesmerized by Nadia, a violent and increasingly “toxic” Raya loses focus on the empire he dreams of building. Their love story starts promisingly. Nadia holds a mirror up

to Raya’s animalistic attitude. “Next time when you make love, I feel like you care about me and not feel attacked,” she tells him. For a while, Nadia seems to have some semblance of personality amid a host of characters who appear plastic (Sudev Nair, as Raaya’s trusted soldier, is completely wasted). But the relationship never blossoms into anything particularly interesting, as *Toxic* crams in one plot point after another. Ujwal Kulkarni’s choppy editing only

makes matters worse, as does the film’s relentless showboating of Raya.

With *Toxic*, Yash makes it clear that he is, above all, an image-conscious star. The dialogues of his character, which he is now understood to have written, feel like they belong to the *KGF* universe. Even his dialogue delivery seems like an extension of his performance in *KGF*. None of it fits the world of *Toxic*.

It’s obvious to wonder how this film could have been, had it made room for more drama. I wonder why every conversation between Raya and his lady love had to lead to sex? Why do filmmakers forget the magic of intense conversation? The five main lead female characters (Huma Qureshi and Rukmini being the other two) start off with promise, but don’t get enough room to make a difference to the story.

Geetu Mohandas’ staging often feels painfully artificial. Characters stand around in fixed positions and deliver their lines, as though they are waiting for their turn to speak. There is little movement, spontaneity or

unpredictability in these scenes; everything feels very carefully arranged and not particularly lived-in.

Raya turns to violence because, at one point, it is the only way he can save his sister Ganga (Nayanthara). But the violence soon becomes inseparable from him, clinging to him like a second skin. After a while though, the endless gunfire and action sequences begin to feel stale and exhausting. There is neither a

compelling reason for Raya’s thirst for blood, nor a worthy adversary to challenge him, until his son Ticket (Yash again), jolts him out of his violent stupor.

That’s when the film touches upon its most interesting idea: the psychology of a gangster who is dead inside after losing the people he loves. Yash gives his all to Raya’s vulnerable moments, even if his committed performance doesn’t always hit the mark. As the reckless Ticket, he is completely unhinged, and once again, the result is more interesting than it is outright perfect.

Toxic finds its purpose far too late. Until then, the film holds our attention largely through its visual grandeur. We sit through all the slick action, gorgeous frames, and enormous production design, desperately hoping that they will eventually be backed by a compelling story. Geetu had an idea, and Yash had a vision for it. But what we finally receive is a mismatched blend of both.

Toxic is currently running in theatres

The
Whisper
Man

Director: James
Ashcroft

Cast: Robert De Niro,
Michelle Monaghan,
Adam Scott, Hamish
Linklater, Owen
Teague, Michael
Keaton

Storyline: When his
son is kidnapped, a
grieving widower
reconnects with his
estranged father to
find his son



Robert
De Niro’s
snooze
fest

English

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Somewhere in the gloom and doom of James Ashcroft’s *The Whisper Man* (based on Alex North’s 2019 novel), lies an interesting film. Alas, it is not this one, as this serial killer-child-in-danger story lurches from one cavernous plot hole to the next without reason or logic. Any sense of danger or impending tragedy is lost in the sagging

storytelling.

The film opens with Detective Amanda Beck (Michelle Monaghan) leading the search for a boy, Neil Spencer (Xavier Montanez). While the police do not find Neil, they find a decomposed body and then we learn of the serial killer terrorising the small town of Featherbank.

Called the Whisper Man, the killer abducts and kills children. The only problem is that the Whisper Man, Frank Carter (Michael Keaton), was caught and has been in prison all these years.

So, did he have an accomplice? Is he able to direct the abductions and killings from prison? Is it a copycat? Into this maelstrom of dread and suspicion comes Tom Kennedy (Adam Scott), a crime writer, with his eight-year-old son, Jake (Acston Luca Porto) after the death of his wife.

When Jake is taken, Tom turns to the only person who can help, Detective Inspector Pete Willis (Robert De Niro), who put Carter away.

One of the suspects is a creepy true crime junkie,

Norman Collins (Hamish Linklater), who lives in a house full of murder memorabilia and has a passion for opera music. *The Whisper Man* is supposed to be about fathers and sons and how the sins of commission and omission by the fathers are visited upon and carried over to the sons. That is all very well and crime has often been used as a framework to comment on the many ills of society. The cardinal error *The Whisper Man* makes is in failing to present a solid mystery.

You are constantly brought out of the film as you puzzle over the weird decisions the characters make. Why do Jake and Tom move into a big, rambling, leaking house that appears to have been chosen solely because the plot requires bodies in the basement? Even if it was Jake who liked the house, as the film seems to imply, what did he like about it, considering he is not able to climb a staircase after finding his mother dead at the foot of the stairs?

How is it that Tom has not told Jake not to talk to strangers and why for the love of God does Tom not tell the police that there was a blue-gloved hand in the letterbox just before Jake was abducted? One can see the solution a mile away even if one has been doing a thousand other things and only giving the screen cursory attention.

Despite the strong cast, everyone seems to have sleepwalked through their roles, the worst offender being De Niro whose constant reaction seems to be a shrug. Produced by the Russo Brothers, the people behind MCU’s greatest hits, *The Whisper Man* is based on a playground rhyme – ‘If your window’s left unlatched, you’ll hear him tapping at the glass/If you’re lonely, sad, and blue, the Whisper Man will come for you’. And the rhyme is far more chilling than the movie.

The *Whisper Man* is currently streaming on Netflix

Snippets



Bethlehem Kudumba Unit
released in Tamil

The latest hit Malayalam movie, *Bethlehem Kudumba Unit*, starring Nivin Pauly and Mamitha Baiju, has been released in Tamil on September 4. Produced by Bhavana Studios and directed by Gireesh AD, the film was released in Malayalam on August 21, opening to positive reviews.

The makers unveiled the song ‘Muttayi Vandi’ on August 31 to announce the news.

Bethlehem Kudumba Unit is a feel-good romance drama that follows the story of a young woman who moves into a new neighbourhood in the city and takes a liking to her older neighbour. With music scored by Vishnu Vijay, the film has cinematography by Ajmal Sabu and editing by Akash Joseph Varghese.



Trisha, Radhika, Aparna team up for
Tamil psychological horror flick

Trisha Krishnan, Radhika Sarathkumar and Aparna Balamurali are teaming up for a new Tamil production.

This yet-to-be-titled psychological drama and horror flick will be directed by filmmaker Raja Krishna Menon, known for films such as *Airlift*, *Chef* and *Pippa*. The project is backed by Panorama Studios, in association with Locomotive Global.

The film has gone on floors, with principal photography now underway. Details about the rest of the starcast and crew are awaited. The project brings together three accomplished actors with an impressive body of work across Tamil, Malayalam and Hindi cinema.



Anshuman Jha and Raghubir Yadav’s
family-drama gets release date

Anshuman Jha and Raghubir Yadav’s upcoming family-drama, *Om Ka Hari*, will be released in theatres on September 18. Directed by Harish Vyas, the film also stars Soni Razdan, Samta Sudiksha and Ayesha Kapur in key roles.

The film marks the third collaboration between Harish and Anshuman, following their previous films, *Angrezi Mein Kehte Hain* and *Hum Bhi Akele*, which also completes the filmmaker’s trilogy on love, as per the makers. *Om Ka Hari* tells a story of a stubborn father in Bhopal and his conflicted relationship with his son, which finds a resolution in Varanasi.



A warm, spirited origin story

Without romanticising the burns, cuts and pains of being a young chef, the Matt Johnson directorial tells the story of the one summer that changed Anthony’s life

English

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You’re going to find out about it anyway. So, here’s some preemptive truth-telling. There’s no way to tell what Anthony Bourdain would have thought about *Tony*. Would he have hated the attention? Would he have brushed it off? There’s more than enough discourse about it.

But one thing’s for sure. Anthony Bourdain has left the kind of impact on the world that only a handful of others may have managed to. Every generation comes around to him one way or the other through books, his shows or bits and pieces now trending on social media platforms.

So, I will let you find and get to know him in your own way, as I did. I’d recommend starting with his book, *Kitchen Confidential*, but I digress.

It has been three weeks since the release of *Tony* in the US, and we finally have the India release. I thought it would be difficult to avoid the critics and articles and keep them from colouring my opinions. Still, despite engaging with all the online chatter, I came away feeling anew.

Tony is a film that demands to be experienced. Whatever the Internet has decided it is – masterpiece, misfire, or something in between – feels besides the point until you have sat through it yourself and felt passion, urgency, joy, pain and sorrow all at once.

Tony does not tell the story of Bourdain’s entire life, and I doubt any single piece of media is capable of doing

Tony

Director: Matt Johnson

Cast: Dominic Sessa,
Antonio Banderas,
Emilia Jones, Dagmara
Domíńczyk, Rich
Sommer, Stavros
Halkias, Leo Woodall

Storyline: A young
Anthony Bourdain
spends one summer in
Provincetown which
changes the trajectory
of his life.

so (looking at you, *Roadrunner*). It tells the story of a lost, rebellious college kid who finds himself in Provincetown, Cape Cod, one summer, and how the kitchen makes him a man. A coming-of-age, if you will.

Anthony (Dominic Sessa), or Tony as he likes to go by, is a brilliant liar. He almost convinces the jury of a writing fellowship of his abilities to write a book on a story that he makes up on the spot. Arrogant, egotistical young Tony walks up to his high-school crush Nancy (Emilia Jones) in a bar afterwards with confidence, and claims to have the fellowship in the bag and invites her to New York. The words “I’m going to Cape Cod for the summer” change the trajectory of his life.

An expert liar, now heartbroken after being rejected from the fellowship, Tony follows a girl to Provincetown. His parents celebrate his acceptance into the fellowship while he angrily punches a Bruce Lee poster, steals money from his father and gets on a bus only to find the object of his desire working in a pizza parlour and gleefully kissing another guy.

Drunk and heartbroken again, Tony picks a fight with the kitchen staff and gets thrown out on the street. The chef (Antonio Banderas), an old, seasoned professional, gives him refuge on his porch and appoints him as a dishwasher. The humble beginnings.

“I was – to be frank – a spoiled, miserable, narcissistic, self-destructive, and thoughtless young lout badly in need of a good a**-kicking,” writes Anthony Bourdain in the chapter titled ‘Food is Sex’ in *Kitchen Confidential*. And a good a**-kicking he got.

Tony is woken up brutally with a pot of salty seawater on his face every morning, and spends his days hunched over the sink washing dishes, and his evenings under the influence and indulging in healthy teenage activities. It is a way of

life in P-town summer. Somewhere along the way, the kitchen becomes the place where he is no longer just washing dishes, but dreaming of something big. Bigger than himself.

He shucks oysters, portions fish, learns how to make sauce and reads Auguste Escoffier’s 1903 classic cookbook, *Le Guide Culinaire* from the chef’s bookshelf.

In a rather casual scene, one day when the restaurant is shut, Tony is woken up again with a pot of water in his face and accompanies the chef to the restaurant to do prep work. While filling salt shakers, Tony is handed his first chef’s coat. A pristine white jacket that he looks at in awe before going right back to the shakers.

It is moments like these that makes *Tony* lived-in. The quiet thrill of being allowed to imagine a different life gives us a glimpse into the mind of a young, misguided boy who had big dreams. Without romanticising the burns, cuts and pains of being a young chef, it brings on screen a story of the one summer that changed his life.

Dominic Sessa’s portrayal of the late chef, with the lose clothing, wide smile, hunched back and brooding look is uncannily convincing. His gait is confident and Sessa is able to bring out a disarmingly tender approach to not just the mannerism but also in the vulnerability beneath. The picturisation of the sleepy beach town in Cape Cod is beautiful and intimate, and almost makes you want to spend a summer there hoping to bump into Tony and dine at the Lobster Pot.

Tony is not a film that leaves you in awe. It’s not a larger-than-life story about a celebrity chef who travelled the world and ate with passion. *Tony* may not leave you inspired, or hopeful, but it will leave you hungry. For food, life, and audacity.

Tony is currently running in theatres.